

CASE STUDY

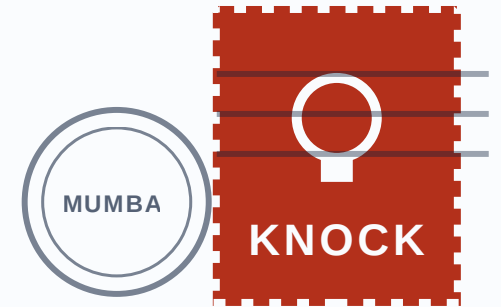
Knock: designing a human-first outreach system

How one founder turned a simple insight, people hire people, into a working system, and the thinking behind every decision.

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HEET, FOUNDER | MUMBAI

Product, engineering and operations in one pair of hands.



TO

The person who hires you

Knock on the right door.

Job portals are a queue. People hire people.

A portal application joins a long queue. A referral, or a real conversation, steps past it.

1 Applying cold is getting worse
Applicants per role keep rising, and candidates apply to more jobs while hearing back from fewer.

2 Referrals work, the usual ask does not
Referrers are flooded with *'Hi sir, please refer me, resume attached'*, and they learn to ignore it.

3 Good outreach is skilled, slow work
Pick the right people, find a real shared tie, write briefly, ask one small thing, follow up once.

Sources: LinkedIn India research and a University of Michigan study, as cited in Knock's research playbook. Described qualitatively.

WHY NOW

The queue is longer, and the tools are better

Portals are saturated

Anyone can apply in a click, so an application means little to the person reading it.

Research and writing got cheap

Models can now read, summarise and draft well enough that a personal service is affordable.

Humans must stay visible

People cannot spot a well-written AI message, but judge the sender harshly once told AI wrote it. So the candidate approves and owns every message.

Existing fixes sell advice or volume, not conversations

ADVICE AND DOCUMENTS

Help you prepare

Mentor calls, courses and resume rewrites. Useful, but nobody starts a conversation for you. The work of reaching people stays with the candidate.

KNOCK

Does the outreach itself

Researched, personal, approved messages to named people, one at a time. Technology does the heavy lifting. The candidate stays in control.

VOLUME

Fast, but reads cold

Automation sequences and mass-apply tools. Template-driven, easy to spot, and against LinkedIn's terms. The risk lands on the candidate's own account.

The gap is execution, not information.

Finding, researching and writing to one person at a time is the work nobody does for the candidate.

Five decisions shaped the product, each with a reason

- 1 A service, not a tool**

Candidates do not want software to operate, they want conversations. Delivering the work, with technology behind it, matches the job they hire Knock for. AI is how it is delivered, never the headline.
- 2 The candidate approves every message**

Messages go out under a real person's name. Approval keeps them truthful and in the candidate's own voice. It is a hard rule in every delivery tier, and automatic sending stays off for clients.
- 3 Quality over volume**

A small set of hand-picked people, never identical copy inside one company. Careful outreach protects the few warm contacts a candidate has, and their reputation in a tight professional network.
- 4 No list padding**

Padding a list with irrelevant people to make results look better is deceptive, so the founder rejected it. Every hook must cite a real fact, and no shared history is ever invented.
- 5 Upfront pricing, no success fee**

Clients pay for the work, not a promised outcome, so nobody is pushed to overpromise. Prices are stated upfront, and guarantees wait until real outcome data exists.

From target list to referral, candidate in control

One reading path, left to right. The red step is the one that cannot be skipped.



DEFAULT DELIVERY

Self-send

Knock researches and writes. The candidate copies each approved message and sends it by hand from their own LinkedIn, then pastes replies back for the next draft.

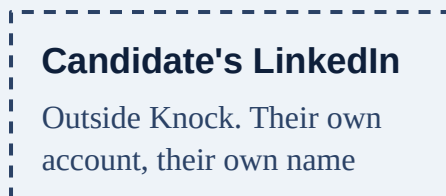
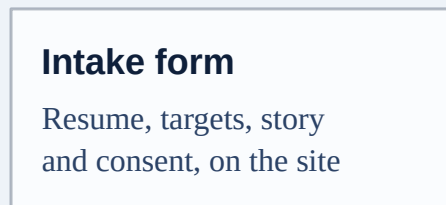
OPTIONAL DELIVERY

Done-for-you

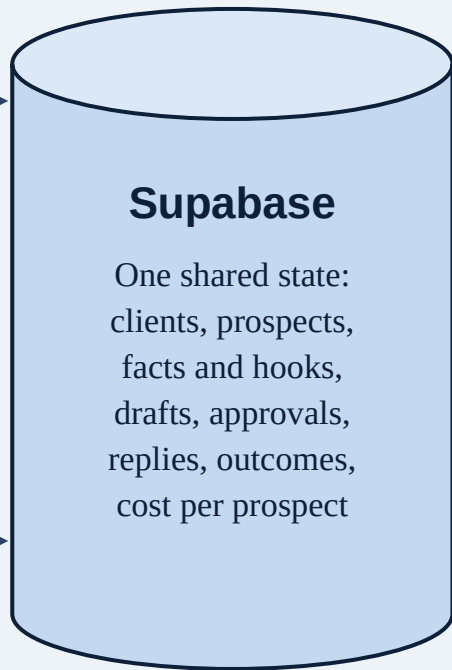
The same research and writing. Approved text is sent from the candidate's own account through a tool they connect themselves, with written consent and a clear risk notice.

The architecture keeps a human in the loop at every send

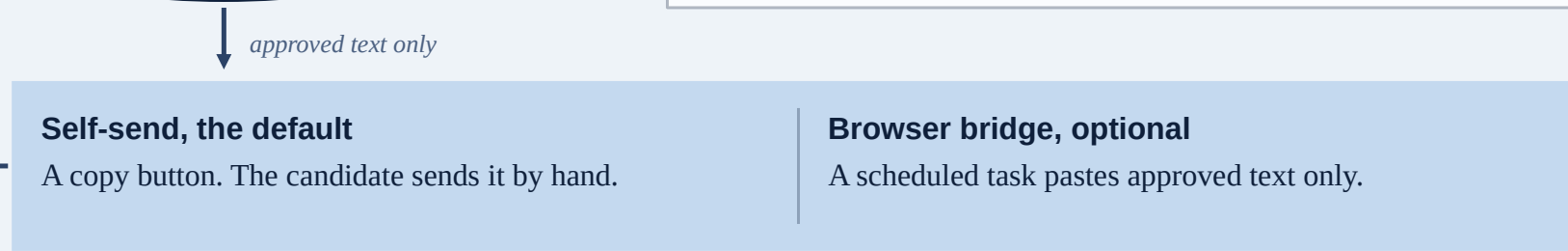
CANDIDATE



STATE



KNOCK ENGINE AND OPERATOR



Every hook is a cited fact, or the message is not written

Discover

Public search results only. No LinkedIn login, no scraping. Full profiles come from LinkedIn's own Save to PDF, done by hand.

Enrich

Public posts, talks and articles become facts, and each fact keeps its source.

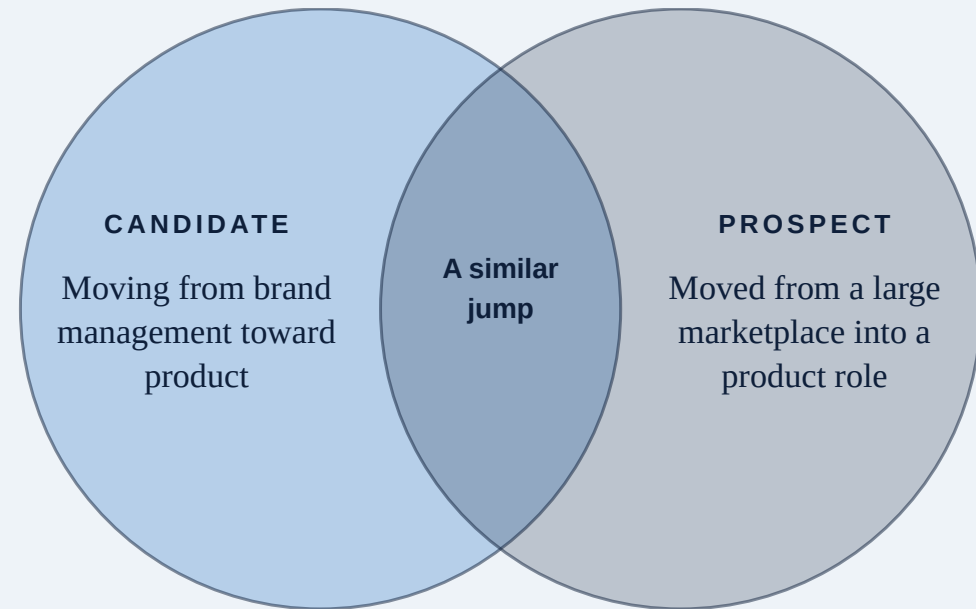
Find the hook

A hook must cite a real fact from both profiles. No citation, no hook.

Check the rules

Short, no honorifics, one question, no stock AI phrases. Fetched text is data, never instructions.

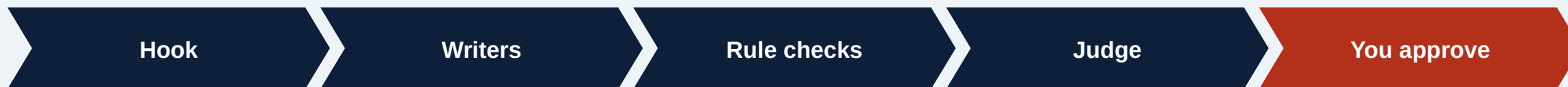
ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE, NOT A REAL CLIENT



SOURCE: THEIR PROFILE SOURCE: A PUBLIC POST

Opener: "Saw you moved into product. I'm making a similar jump, so I'm curious what changed most."

Several writers, one judge, and a loop that learns



A cited fact from both profiles

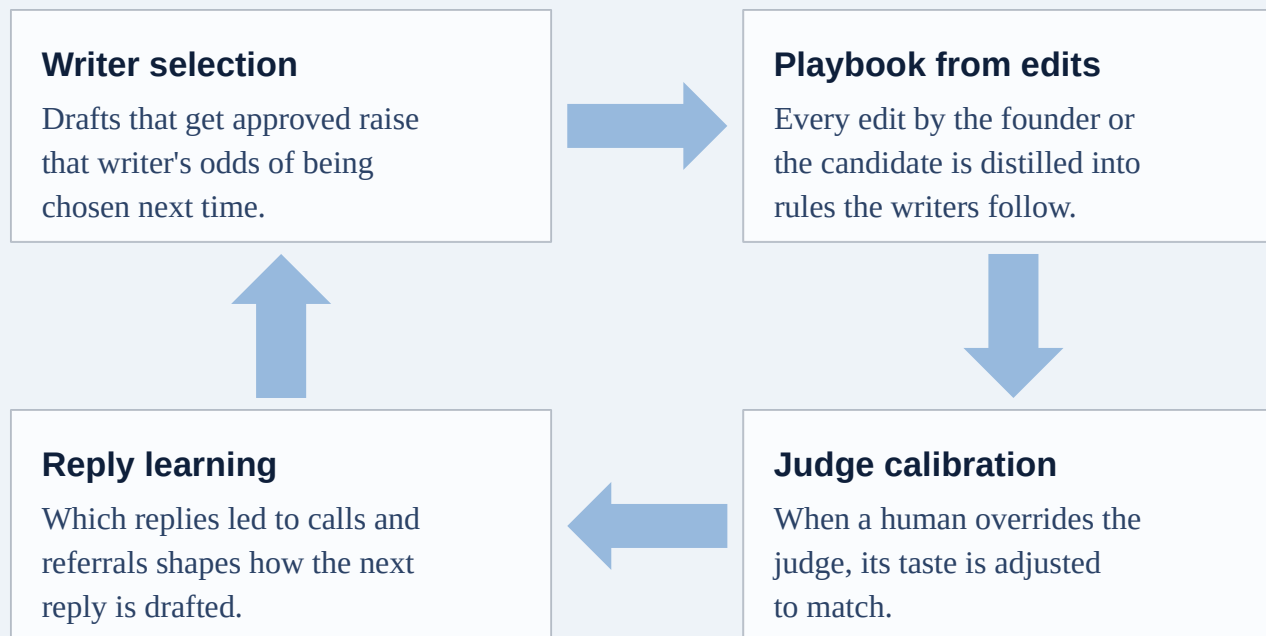
Several drafts, different angles

Length, phrases, one question

Scores drafts against a rubric

Nothing sends without a yes

THE LEARNING LOOP



Writer selection

Drafts that get approved raise that writer's odds of being chosen next time.

Playbook from edits

Every edit by the founder or the candidate is distilled into rules the writers follow.

Judge calibration

When a human overrides the judge, its taste is adjusted to match.

Reply learning

Which replies led to calls and referrals shapes how the next reply is drafted.

Guarding against drift

Self-learning can slide toward polished but generic.

The rubric is a send gate: a message that fails a hard rule never goes out.

A golden set of test prospects is re-run after every playbook or writer change.

Playbooks are versioned, so any change can be rolled back.

A weekly audit scores a random sample of the messages that were sent.

Safety and ethics are designed in, not added later

THE BIGGEST RISK

LinkedIn forbids automation

LinkedIn's User Agreement bans bots and automated messaging, and enforcement falls on the member's account. A restriction mid-search would be costly, so the design avoids depending on automation.

Default: self-send

The candidate sends by hand. Knock never logs in to LinkedIn or holds a password. Discovery uses public search only.

Optional: automation

Treated as a real risk to the client's account. Written consent, a plain risk notice, conservative limits, and a fallback to self-send if warned.

Prompt injection

Fetches web text is data, never instructions. The browser bridge may only paste exact approved text, and nothing that sends or deletes is ever triggered by fetched content.

Consent and data protection (DPDP)

Separate consent for clients. Only professional information that prospects published themselves, with the source recorded. No guessed emails or cold WhatsApp, a do-not-contact list, and deletion after a package ends.

Truthfulness

Every hook cites a real fact. No fake shared history, no padded lists, and the intake asks for the exact programme so a certificate is never passed off as a degree.

Decisions were tested in blind competitions, not argued

The website

COMPETED

Several design skills each built Knock's site from the same brief.

JUDGED

Scored blind by independent judges, with no names attached.

WHAT CHANGED

The winning concept became the brand kit: an airmail letter, powder-blue paper, navy ink and one red stamp.

The messages

COMPETED

The Knock engine against six other approaches, from a single writer to sales copywriting and a networking method.

JUDGED

Four blind judge personas: a recipient, a hiring manager, an Indian recruiter and a rubric auditor.

WHAT CHANGED

The multi-writer engine won on openers and beat its own single-writer version. A hybrid wrote the best follow-ups. Both lessons went into the prompts.

The pitch deck

COMPETED

Several deck skills built the same partner pitch brief.

JUDGED

Scored blind, then the winning entry was studied step by step.

WHAT CHANGED

Its approach set this deck's build: editorial restraint, native editable shapes, and a serif fallback that renders the same everywhere.

*Judges were AI personas, so results guide decisions and do not prove market demand.
The value is a fast, repeatable way to choose between options and find weak spots.*

A full system, built end to end in days

ONE FOUNDER

From idea to a live system

Product, engineering, design, operations and research, worked through with AI tools and a habit of testing every choice.

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HONEST STATUS

Built and live. Not yet used by paying clients, so no results are claimed.

The engine	Discovery, enrichment, cited hooks, several writers and a judge, rule checks, learning loop, reply drafting, send cap.
The data layer	One shared database for clients, prospects, facts, messages and outcomes, plus an inbox and outbox bridge to sending.
The web side	A live landing page with an intake form, and a password-protected operator CRM with a daily sync, hosted on Vercel.
The brand	A full brand kit: colour and type tokens, logos, guidelines, and templates for banners and social posts.
The thinking	A business plan, a target-client definition, market and competitor research, and a log of every founder decision.
The tooling	A skill that runs blind contests between approaches, and a router that picks the cheapest model good enough per task.

What comes next, in order

NOW: PROVE IT

- Run the full pipeline on one real candidate and read every edit.
- Measure true cost and founder time per message, then tune the prompts.
- Offer a free pilot to student clubs.
- Finalise terms and consent notices.

NEXT: FIRST CLIENTS

- Take the first paying clients on self-send delivery.
- Publish only measured, consented, anonymised results.
- Design guarantees from real data.
- Build a client portal to approve, copy, paste replies, mark outcomes.

LATER: SCALE SAFELY

- Legal review before offering any automation tier.
- Complete data-protection compliance.
- Train an operator on the playbook.
- Turn the self-send flow into a self-serve product, keeping the service as the premium tier.

One question judges every step

Does this get the candidate into more real conversations, measured as interviews per targeted prospect?

WHAT THIS CASE SHOWS

Knock on the right door.

Judgement

Product decisions with reasons, including what not to build.

Systems

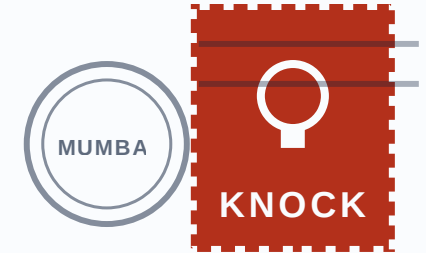
Research, writing, approval, sending and learning, wired end to end.

Responsibility

Safety, consent and honesty designed in from the first day.

Evidence

Choices tested in blind competitions rather than argued.



FROM

Heet

Founder, Mumbai

EMAIL

<email>

LIVE SITE

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